PARSHAT CHAYEI SARAH · SHIUR READER

בַּת שָׁלֹשׁ שָׁנִים

WAS RIVKAH REALLY THREE?

Rashi says Rivkah was three years old when she married Yitzchak. People hear that and think the Torah is absurd. Here is the math behind Rashi, and a reading that turns a troubling number into a portrait of the Jewish people's next Avraham.

RAV EITAN BENDAVID · KEHILLAT SHIVTEI YISRAEL, RA'ANANA · 6 MIN VIDEO · WATCH THE SHIUR →

STEP ONE: THE MATH

Three facts come straight from the pesukim. Sarah lives to 127. She is 90 when Yitzchak is born, so Yitzchak is 37 when she dies. And Yitzchak is 40 when he marries Rivkah.

BEREISHIT 25:20

וַיְהִי יִצְחָק בֶּן־אַרְבָּעִים שָׁנָה בְּקַחְתּוֹ אֶת־רִבְקָה בַּת־בְּתוּאֵל הָאֲרַמִּי מִפַּדַּן אֲרָם אֲחוֹת לָבָן הָאֲרַמִּי לוֹ לְאִשָּׁה׃

Yitzchak was forty years old when he took Rivkah, daughter of Betuel the Aramean of Paddan-aram, sister of Lavan the Aramean, as his wife.

Three things the Torah *doesn't* say: when Rivkah was born, exactly when Sarah died, and how old Yitzchak was at the Akeidah. Rashi, following the Midrash, assumes all three happen at once. Avraham comes down from Har HaMoriah, Sarah dies on hearing the news, and Avraham is told that Rivkah has been born (22:20–23). Yitzchak is 37, so three years later at his wedding, Rivkah is three.

RASHI ON BEREISHIT 25:20

בן ארבעים שנה. שֶׁהֲרֵי כְּשֶׁבָּא אַבְרָהָם מֵהַר הַמּוֹרִיָּה נִתְבַּשֵּׂר שֶׁנּוֹלְדָה רִבְקָה, וְיִצְחָק הָיָה בֶּן ל"ז שָׁנָה, שֶׁהֲרֵי בּוֹ בַּפֶּרֶק מֵתָה שָׂרָה, וּמִשֶּׁנּוֹלַד יִצְחָק עַד הָעֲקֵדָה שְׁמֹנָה שָׂרָה, ל"ז שָׁנָה הָיוּ – כִּי בַּת צ' הָיְתָה כְּשֶׁנּוֹלַד יִצְחָק, וּבַת קכ"ז כְּשֶׁמֵּתָה – שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר וַיִּהְיוּ חַיֵּי שָׂרָה וְגוֹ' הֲרֵי לְיִצְחָק ל"ז שָׁנִים, וּבוֹ בַּפֶּרֶק נוֹלְדָה רִבְקָה; הִמְתִּין לָהּ עַד שֶׁתְּהֵא רְאוּיָה לְבִיאָה ג' שָׁנִים וּנְשָׂאָהּ׃

When Avraham came from Mount Moriah he received the news that Rivkah was born. Yitzchak was then thirty-seven… and at that very time Rivkah was born. He waited for her three years, and married her.

STEP TWO: WHAT DOES IT MEAN?

- **Innocence.** Later Rivkah will make hard, even deceptive choices to secure the blessing for Yaakov. Here she is pure and innocent.
- **Loss and rebirth.** The moment Sarah dies, the next matriarch is born. Loss gives way to hope.
- **The Rav's reading: Rivkah is the next Avraham.**

RIVKAH AND AVRAHAM

No one in Bereishit resembles Avraham more than Rivkah. He left his land and family for Eretz Yisrael, and so does she, with one word:

BEREISHIT 24:58

וַיִּקְרְאוּ לְרִבְקָה וַיֹּאמְרוּ אֵלֶיהָ הֲתֵלְכִי עִם־הָאִישׁ הַזֶּה וַתֹּאמֶר אֵלֵךְ׃

"Will you go with this man?" And she said, "I will go."

Avraham had to choose between two sons, Yitzchak and Yishmael. Rivkah must choose between Yaakov and Esav. And the numbers line up too:

NEDARIM 32A

בֶּן שָׁלֹשׁ שָׁנִים הִכִּיר אַבְרָהָם אֶת בּוֹרְאוֹ

At three years old, Avraham recognized his Creator.

RAMBAM, HILCHOT AVODAH ZARAH 1:3

וּבֶן אַרְבָּעִים שָׁנָה הִכִּיר אַבְרָהָם אֶת בּוֹרְאוֹ

And at forty years old, Avraham recognized his Creator.

THE PARALLEL

Avraham begins his search at **3** and comes to know Hashem at **40**. **Rivkah** begins her journey at **3**, and marries Yitzchak when he is **40**.

> *"Rivkah was "three" because she was just like Avraham: precocious, spiritual, searching. Am Yisrael continues because she is the bridge from Avraham to Yaakov."*
>
> —RAV EITAN BENDAVID

FOR THE SHABBAT TABLE

1. Why might Chazal tell us Rivkah's age through a chain of inferences rather than state it outright?
2. Avraham hears "Lech lecha"; Rivkah answers "Elech." What is the difference between being told to go and choosing to go?
3. Who in your life has been a "bridge" carrying something from one generation to the next?